

Navigating Prenatal Trauma (Part 1)

with Dr. Arielle Schwartz

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AGENDA

Recognizing Prenatal & Birth Trauma
Restoring Primal Rhythms
Q & A
Breakout Sessions

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Prenatal Trauma Themes

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What is an Imprint?

- Konrad Lorenz discovered that geese (and other young animals) would form a strong attachment to the first moving object they see after hatching.
- Discussed the period after “hatching” as a critical phase of development for trauma. “A window of plasticity”



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What is an Imprint?

- Arthur Janov's work, particularly his book ***Imprints: The Lifelong Effects of the Birth Experience***, directly links the concept of early life **imprints** (prenatal and birth trauma stored as implicit, somatic memories) to symptoms in adulthood.
- Early trauma occurs before cognitive and verbal abilities develop, these experiences are stored as physiological or "somatic" imprints in the nervous system and body, rather than as conscious, narrative memories.

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Trauma Imprints (Porges)

- An imprint is a state-dependent implicit memory held within the nervous system.
- Interoception signals become tagged as a threat by the brainstem which recalibrates and biases the autonomic nervous system toward chronic defense.
- The imprint persists as an autonomic template: the body's implicit memory of danger.
- Defensive states persist, even when safety is cognitively known— but safety is not felt.

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What solidifies the imprint?

- Encoding of threat responsiveness is strengthened by vasopressin
- Flexibility and softening of the imprint is strengthened by oxytocin
- Oxytocin and vasopressin are partner hormones that are localized in brain regions critical for social connection (Carter, 2017).

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Oxytocin, Vasopressin, and Social Bonding

- Individuals who have experienced early childhood trauma may be prone to a paradoxical response to oxytocin.
- Instead of being motivated to express positive, prosocial feelings, these individuals are more likely to respond to oxytocin with defensive emotional or behavioral responses.
- Relational trauma can lead one to rely upon self-defensive and protective strategies as soon as a need for connection arises.
- Withdrawal, fear, or aggression are more likely to arise in response to opportunities for closeness.

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Prenatal Imprints

- **Conception trauma**
- **Incarnating isn't welcome or safe**
- **Being unwanted/Rejected**
- **Is it safe to exist**
- **Ancestral imprinting**
- **Twin themes (who got the resources)**
- **Toxicity (drugs or alcohol)**
- **Violence (rape, violence in the womb)**
- **First sense of containment**

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Birth Imprints

- **Stopping and Starting (Interruption themes)**
- **Medical traumas during birth (induction, forceps, c-section, cord complications, anesthesia)**
- **Postnatal separation (incubators, early medical interventions, NICU, lack of touch)**
- **Emerging (safe to be seen, to take up space)**
- **Getting stuck & rescue themes**
- **Transition themes (always late, difficulty with transitions or endings)**

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Recognizing pre- & perinatal trauma

- Being result of an unwanted pregnancy.
- The mother experienced verbal or physical abuse during pregnancy.
- The mother used drugs or alcohol during pregnancy.
- The mother had a lack of medical care during pregnancy.
- The parents experienced a relationship loss during the mother's pregnancy, such as separation, divorce, illness, or death in the family.
- The mother experienced depression during pregnancy.
- The mother had medical issues during the pregnancy.

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Recognizing pre- & perinatal trauma

- There was a premature birth.
- There were complications during the birth process.
- There were unwanted or invasive medical interventions during the client's birth.
- The client spent time in an incubator as an infant.
- The client has adoption-related concerns or issues.
- There were gender-related stressors such as parents wanting a boy but having a girl.
- The mother had unresolved PTSD.

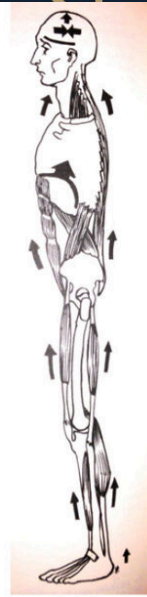
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The In-utero Wound & the Body

Primal Freeze: A Stress response where the nervous system becomes immobilized due to a perceived threat that cannot be fought or fled.

- **Age of the wound:** prenatal to 6 months
- **Unmet need to feel safe to exist, protected, wanted**
- **Wound:** World is unsafe, hostile
- **Belief:** I do not belong; It is not safe to exist
- **Defenses:** Withdraws into Fantasy, Disorientation, Intellectual or Analytical Dissociation
- **Body:** Fragmented, awkward, uncoordinated, robotic, diaphragmatic freeze frozen at core, pulling away from gravity, cannot yield



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Psychological & Somatic Themes

- **Can I receive:** is receiving contaminated with toxicity?
- **Containment:** am I safely held, trapped vs. contained? Am I part of the whole?
- **Interruption of rhythm:** Can I sense myself? Can I maintain a sense of self while I connect to you?
- **Loss of vagal tone:** Interruptions in the psychobiological rhythms

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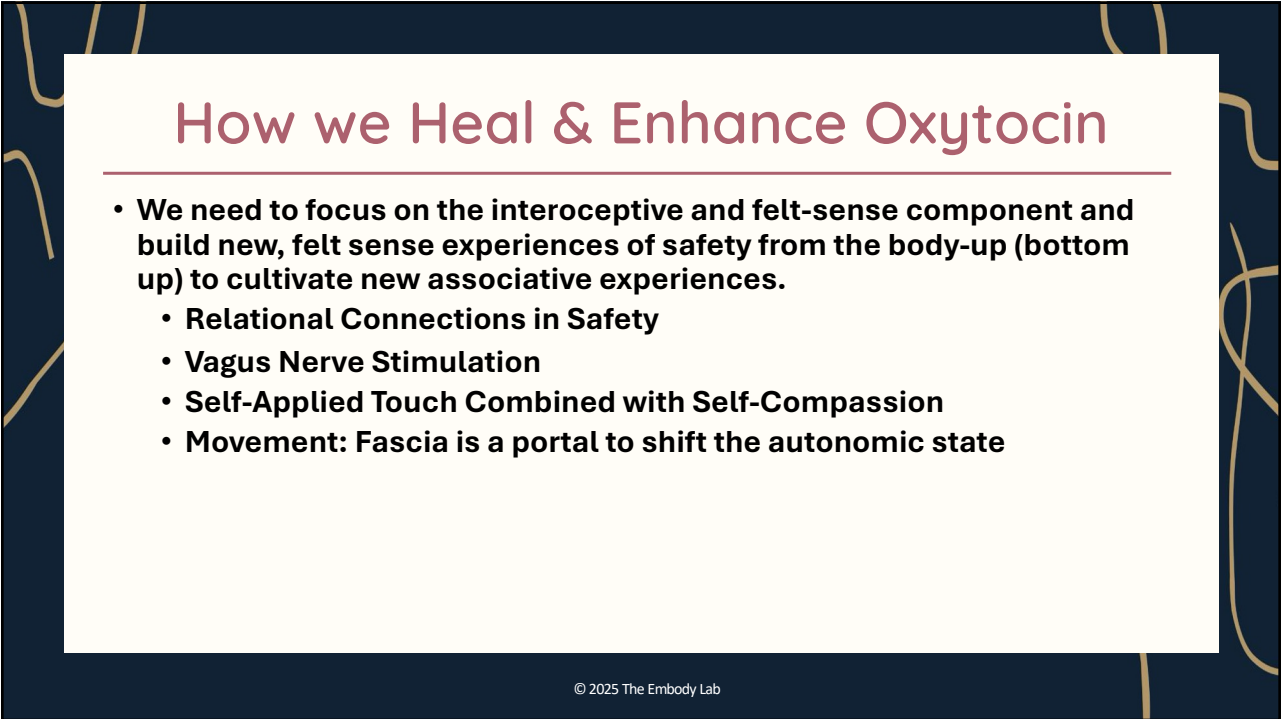
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Restoring Primal Rhythms

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How we Heal & Enhance Oxytocin

- **We need to focus on the interoceptive and felt-sense component and build new, felt sense experiences of safety from the body-up (bottom up) to cultivate new associative experiences.**
 - **Relational Connections in Safety**
 - **Vagus Nerve Stimulation**
 - **Self-Applied Touch Combined with Self-Compassion**
 - **Movement: Fascia is a portal to shift the autonomic state**

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Spacious Relational Awareness

- It is important that you feel safe enough with me as we work together. Is it okay with you if I periodically invite you to take a brief pause from the story you are sharing with me? This way, I can help you pace yourself and reduce the likelihood that you will end therapy feeling overwhelmed.
- I would like to remind you that there is plenty of time and space for you. There is no need to rush.
- Can you take a moment to sense your body while you share your story?
- Can you take a moment to sense your emotions while you share your story?
- What you are saying is important. I want to be sure that I can stay present with you and all that you are sharing with me. What I am noticing right now is... (e.g. a reflection of the expression that you notice on the client's face, an emotion or sensation that you are aware of in yourself, etc.)

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Restoring Primal Rhythms

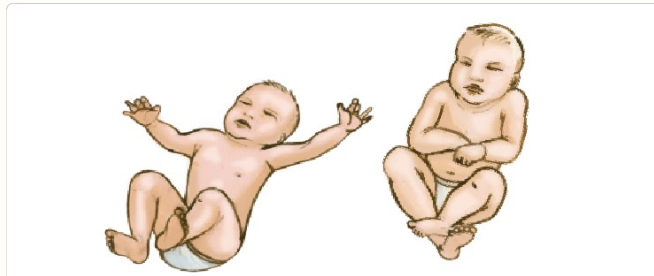
- Is the birth story known? Sensing the body's response to the narrative (listen for congruence)
- Imagine being in the body of the mother.
- Unwinding Freeze: Movement, Breath, Touch
- Settling into the organs of your body: Unwinding the Viscera

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Restoring Primal Rhythms

- **Integration of the Moro Reflex & Restoration of primal rhythms:**
 - **Flexion & Extension**



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Shock, Orienting Response, & the Fear Paralysis & Moro Reflexes (Corrigan & Sands, 2020; Musgatova, 2016)

- **Orienting Response & Pre-Affective Shock:** Before you have an affective response, orienting response to threat & somatic tension
- **Fear Paralysis and Moro Reflexes:** Startle response that expands away from center followed up a contraction to center and a sharp inhale.
- **When unresolved, can exacerbate symptoms of PTSD such as:**
 - anxiety, phobias, insomnia, fatigue, lack of trust, avoidant behaviors, depression, dependency, vulnerability to emotional overwhelm, freezing, dissociation from one's body, inability to cope with stress, vulnerable to asthma and digestive issues.



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Restoring Primal Rhythms

Vagal Toning:

- **Safe mobilization:** Play, Move, Initiate, Explore with Curiosity, Dance, Create, Reach, Stretch, Instinctual Movements, Shake, Release
- **Safe immobilization:** Relax, Rest, Savor, Receive, Digest, Sleep, Meditation, Yoga Nidra, Spiritual States
 - Physiological sigh
 - Mindful self-touch (havening touch)
 - Auricular massage of the tragus, ear lobe, & concha
 - SCM release
 - Abdominal massage & release

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Discussion Prompts

1. Discuss as a group your takeaways about how to recognize pre or perinatal trauma.
2. As you learn about this material and practice the restoration of primal rhythms, what arises for you personally in relationship to your own pre- peri natal history?
3. How did you respond to the invitation to engage in the vagal toning practices? How does your body let you know when you feel safe?

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QUESTIONS

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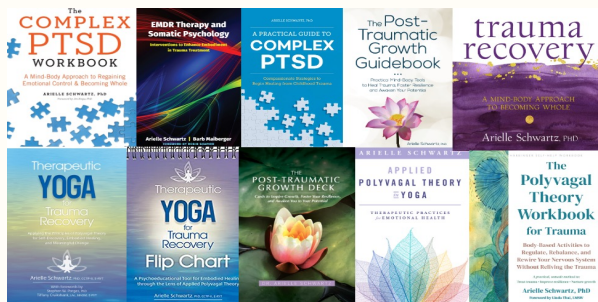
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